

## "The rights of Sri Lankan Tamils should not get enmeshed in the hostilities."

PRANAB MUKHERJEE, EXTERNAL AFFAIRS MINISTER, INDIA

when Rajapakse was quoted in the local media as saying Sri Lanka had informed India that it was not ready to enter into a ceasefire with the LTTE. Backing him up was LTTE defector Sivanesanuraj Chandrakanthan, now the chief minister of the Eastern Province and a staunch Rajapakse ally, who said if the Government stopped its military drive now, it would be detrimental to the Tamil people.

With troops closing in on the LTTE's main political stronghold of

displaced by the latest fighting, according to international NGOs, a figure government officials say could be inflated. Food and other essentials are sent by road to the displaced who have sought shelter in government-controlled areas as well as within rebel territory. Rajapakse has insisted that he is safeguarding the residents of those areas, saying that his security forces were fighting under severe constraints to prevent civilian casualties. But his

Indo-Sri Lanka accord, India is wary of becoming militarily involved in the on-going conflict and has stopped short of calling for a ceasefire. But it has once again reiterated that the Sri Lankan government must come up with a credible devolution package that addresses the concerns of the Tamils.

So far, Rajapakse has not seen his popularity dip despite inflation riding at nearly 25 per cent, mounting casualty figures and a steadily increasing war budget.



**FIGHTING IT OUT:** A protest against Tamil killings in Sri Lanka

Kilinochchi, the Government is claiming that the end is in sight for the campaign which began in 2007 to dislodge the LTTE from the island's north and east. Rajapakse's Government, which pulled out of a truce brokered by Norway in January, said that this will be a fight to the finish. It has been unmoved by the strong displeasure of the international community. Although India has been steadfast in refusing to provide arms to the Government, military assistance in the form of intelligence-sharing and equipment has been forthcoming.

Caught up in the hostilities are an estimated 230,000 civilians who have been internally

assurances have not convinced pro-LTTE parties in Tamil Nadu.

Concerned that if the DMK MPs, including its ministers in the Union cabinet, may carry out their threat of mass resignations, Singh even called up Rajapakse and expressed his reservations about the way the war is being conducted, emphasising India's stand that there was "no military solution to the ethnic conflict". He also called for the safety of Indian fishermen trawling Lankan seas. The DMK's threat is seen by some as posturing to thwart other Tamil Nadu parties from exploiting Tamil sentiments over the war in Lanka. Having burnt its fingers after the 1987

The conflict has provided a rallying point for nationalist parties. However, although Rajapakse has convened an all-party conference to address the issue, in reality it is a lame duck committee that does not have representation from the main opposition United National Party, the hardline Janatha Vimukthi Peramuna and the LTTE's parliamentary proxy, the Tamil National Alliance, all three of which are vital for any authentic attempt to redress the grievances of the island's Tamil minority. There is concern though that if the war is prolonged, people's patience may run out.

*with bureau reports from Delhi*